

In Book V of *The Gay Science*, Nietzsche questions topics that are commonly accepted as being black or white, and deconstructs them until he finds the grey area that lies beneath. In Nietzsche's exploration of consciousness, language, and identity, he critiques the constant pursuit of knowledge, certainty, and familiarity. In what follows, I will explore Nietzsche's critiques of these topics, focusing on the dangers he presents about the superficiality of consciousness, always seeking to “know”, and the confinement of over-identification with societal roles, as these prevent us from embracing the free spirit.

In ancient times, as Nietzsche writes, man was “the most endangered animal” (pp. 213), and as a result he needed the help, protection, warning, and advice that comes from a community of equals. In order to express that he needed food, he had to be aware of his hunger. Once he became conscious of this he could give language to it, and through this language he could communicate his needs to others. Thus, the development of consciousness and language happened parallel to each other. From this, Nietzsche concludes that consciousness did not arise from an individual need, but rather from “the community and herd aspects of [human] nature” (pp. 213), for we only became conscious of the things we needed to communicate to the herd.

In Nietzsche's view, what goes on inside our minds is inherently unique. We are singularities who contain multitudes. And though others may have similar thoughts, experiences, and feelings, they can never be exactly the same as our own. For example, in math there is something called an “asymptote”. If you picture a graph with a curve on it, the asymptote is the tangent line that infinitely approaches the curve, but never actually touches it. All the way into infinity, the line will get closer and closer to the curve, but they will never touch. Our individual

thoughts, experiences, and feelings are asymptotically related to others in this way. Though my experience may be almost exactly like yours, they will never be fully the same experience. Our lines will never touch. However, Nietzsche argues that to become conscious of our individual thoughts, experiences, and feelings is inherently to make them communicable - even if just to ourselves. To do this is to approximate the numbers in the equation, and thereby let the line and curve touch.

In other words, in order to bring something from our unconscious to our conscious mind, we translate it from unique, intangible, and complex to understandable, digestible, and ultimately, superficial. This is because *language generalizes*: we only have words for experiences that are common enough to necessitate a word in the first place. Therefore, language does not truly represent the individual, but the herd - and to give language to one's unique inner world is to lasso it, to trap it, to domesticate it. To communicate something, we have to confine it into words. As a result, we generalize it, or as Nietzsche says, "[translate it] back into the herd perspective" (pp. 213). Accordingly, what we communicate is only an approximation of the unconscious inner world from which our conscious thoughts stem.

So how do we know ourselves, if knowing ourselves requires being self-conscious, and consciousness can only approximate the inner reality? For Nietzsche, there really is no way to ever fully know something, even yourself. Nietzsche writes that our desire for knowledge is "the will to uncover among everything strange, unusual, and doubtful something which no longer unsettles us" (pp. 214). This desire for knowledge is reflected in the desire to "become conscious" of our unconscious realm, so that we might have some control over a part of our mind that we see as strange and unknowable. We believe that by familiarizing ourselves with the strange and unknowable parts of ourselves we can reach a point at which we can say we *know*

ourselves. This demonstrates Nietzsche's belief that knowledge is "nothing more than this: something unfamiliar is to be traced back to something familiar" (pp. 214). We believe that we know something when we become familiar with it, or can connect it to things we are already familiar with. Once we are familiar with something, it becomes less scary, and that's really what the desire for knowledge boils down to: the desire to be less scared by what is unfamiliar to us. Such is the case with becoming conscious of our unconscious, or in other words, becoming familiar with the vast intangible realm inside ourselves.

However, Nietzsche warns against always seeking to *know*. He implies that there is no free spirit¹ in the familiar, what is "known". By calcifying in our knowledge, we cease to view the familiar "as a problem, to see [it] as strange, as distant, as 'outside us'" (pp. 215). Thus, it can become a hiding place one goes to to avoid experiencing the unconscious, unknown, and uncertain side of life. This is a problem for Nietzsche because the unconscious, unknown, and uncertain is where he believes the uniqueness of life happens. To him, it is essential to experience life unanchored to consciousness and knowing, and to instead approach everything with curiosity and questioning. Once we stop questioning the world around us, we lose touch with the free spirit within ourselves. After all, the final metamorphosis of the free spirit in Nietzsche's *Thus Spoke Zarathustra* is to become a child: one who is always curious, who won't stop asking "why?", who plays all different roles, and plays often (pp. 114).

Similar to the way we can become confined by always seeking the knowable, the familiar, conscious thought, and communicability, we can become confined by an "inner longing for a role and mask, for an appearance" (pp. 225). We often identify with the parts of ourselves we emphasize more - the parts we want to show to the world, the parts of ourselves we're proud

¹ Nietzsche's notion of the free spirit is expanded upon later in this essay. Refer to my "First Short Homework Assignment" for a more in-depth explanation.

of and can live with in good conscience. These selective parts that we identify with become the mask that we show to other people, the cloak that we hide under, and the role we play on the stage that is our world.

Like the child in *Thus Spoke Zarathustra*, we are capable of playing many roles. As Nietzsche believes, people do not just have one identity - we are multiplicities (pp. 215-216). However, the danger comes when we over-identify with one role. When we don't just play it occasionally, we *become* it. There is a safety in adopting a mask and playing a role: there is control, less uncertainty, less vulnerability. But as Nietzsche implies at the end of section 359, this safety we may feel comes from a rejection and fear of the free spirit, and in the end, is not life affirming.

In section 355 of Book V of his *Gay Science*, Nietzsche claims that all knowledge is just new things being traced back to familiar things, however I believe this to be an overgeneralization. To me, his claim holds true in many cases, such as “day-to-day” encounters with new information, or new knowledge about people, spaces, music, or art. But I feel there is a different type of knowledge we can access, for example when it comes to complex mathematics, bodily function (like learning how to walk when you are a baby), or even the knowledge gained from experiencing an emotion for the first time. This type of knowledge is formed independently of what we already know. It requires entirely new neurons to be formed in our brains, rather than having a synapse (or connection) form between existing neurons: the latter would be the case with new knowledge that relies on the familiar.

When I took calculus for the first time, it felt like I was learning a new language. There were symbols and concepts and rules that were completely and totally foreign to me. It was unlike any other math I had ever done, and to learn it, I had to blindly follow the steps the

professor laid out for us. I couldn't rely on the algebraic formulas or geometric rules that I was familiar with. But as I was given new sets of formulas and rules, and practiced solving problems with these, I started to understand calculus. In this way, I formed new knowledge independently of what I already knew and was familiar with.

Of course, one could argue that I still related the calculus I was learning to things I was familiar with, for example numbers, mathematic notation, and arithmetic. But for me, it seems like a stretch to say that the new knowledge I learned boiled down *only* to the fact that I was relating new concepts to familiar foundations, and that is the main difference upon which my argument lies. We may need to be familiar with basic foundations of the world around us to be able to learn new knowledge, but I would argue that rather than relating all new things to familiar things, the familiar *primes* us to be able to grasp and conceive of new knowledge; particularly when it comes to these fields like complex mathematics, bodily function/control, and emotional development.

Throughout *The Gay Science*, as we have seen, Nietzsche warns of the dangers of seeking certainty and familiarity in consciousness, knowledge, and over-identification with roles, as these things lead to a loss of the free spirit within ourselves. Similarly, he warns that adopting roles and masks can lead us to confine ourselves into a singular identity, which stifles the inherent multiplicity within all of us. Nietzsche instead advocates for embracing the free spirit by unbinding from the safety of the "known", the conscious, the communicable, roles and masks, and instead approaching life as a child might: with curiosity, questioning, and a playfulness. Because in essence, the true metamorphosis into a free spirit requires transcending the safety of familiarity, generality, roles, and masks, and fully embracing the uncertainty, uniqueness, and multifaceted nature of life.